LESSON 1

Introduction to Management

Learning outcomes. By the end of this lesson you should be able to:

- define the concept of management;
- list the four basic functions of management;
- describe the three levels of management in an organisation;
- identify key skills required of effective managers.

1.1 What is management?

Management is the process of planning, organising, leading and controlling resources to achieve organisational goals efficiently and effectively. It involves making decisions, allocating resources, and guiding people toward desired outcomes.

Worked example

A small café owner decides the menu (planning), orders supplies and schedules staff (organising), motivates employees during a busy lunch (leading), and checks daily sales to adjust prices if needed (controlling). This whole sequence is management.

1.2 The four functions of management

1. **Planning** – setting objectives and deciding how to achieve them.
2. **Organising** – arranging tasks, people and resources to implement the plan.
3. **Leading** – influencing and motivating people to work toward the goals.
4. **Controlling** – monitoring performance and making corrections as needed.

Worked example

A university department plans to increase enrolment (planning), creates new course sections and hires adjunct lecturers (organising), holds faculty meetings to communicate the vision (leading), and reviews enrolment numbers each semester to adjust marketing efforts (controlling).

1.3 Levels of management

Organisations typically have three hierarchical levels:

- **Top management** – sets overall direction, formulates strategy, and represents the organisation to external stakeholders.
- **Middle management** – translates strategic goals into operational plans, coordinates departments, and reports to top management.
- **First-line (operational) management** – supervises daily activities, manages frontline staff, and ensures tasks are completed on time.

Worked example

In a retail chain, the CEO (top management) decides to expand into a new market, the regional manager (middle management) develops a rollout plan for stores, and the store manager (first-line) schedules staff shifts and monitors sales each day.

1.4 Key managerial skills

Effective managers need a mix of skills:

- **Technical skills** – knowledge of specific tools, processes or industry practices.
- **Human skills** – ability to communicate, motivate and work with people.
- **Conceptual skills** – capacity to see the whole organisation, understand relationships and think strategically.

Worked example

A project manager uses technical skills to understand software development tools, human skills to resolve team conflicts, and conceptual skills to align the project with the company's long-term strategy.

Key test. Ask yourself: Do I need to set goals, organise resources, guide people and check results? If yes, I am performing management. Identify which of the four functions I am using most in a given situation.

1.5 Exercises

1. Write a short paragraph defining management in your own words.
2. For a student club, list one activity that belongs to each of the four management functions.
3. Match the following roles to the appropriate level of management: (a) Chief Financial Officer, (b) Department Supervisor, (c) Team Leader.
4. Give an example of a situation where a manager needs strong conceptual skills rather than technical skills.

1.6 Key terms

Term	Meaning
Management	Planning, organising, leading and controlling resources to achieve goals.
Planning	Setting objectives and deciding how to achieve them.
Organising	Arranging tasks, people and resources to implement plans.
Leading	Influencing and motivating people toward goals.
Controlling	Monitoring performance and correcting deviations.
Top management	Senior executives who set overall direction and strategy.
Middle management	Managers who translate strategy into operational plans.
First-line management	Supervisors who oversee daily activities and staff.
Technical skills	Knowledge of specific tools or processes.
Human skills	Ability to communicate and work with people.
Conceptual skills	Ability to understand the organisation as a whole and think strategically.